



CHLOROFORM

Another anesthetic drug that appeared around the same time as ether was chloroform. It was first used by the Scottish doctor James Young Simpson in 1847 to relieve women's pain during childbirth. Some people objected to this use, believing it "unnatural." However, Britain's Queen Victoria allowed Simpson to use chloroform to soothe her birthing pains in 1853.

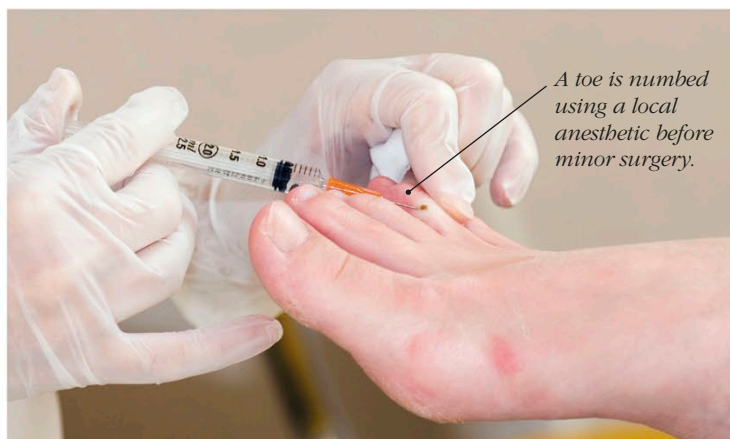
Bottle of chloroform from the late 19th century

WOW!

Used to numb pain in the early 19th century, the gas nitrous oxide made people feel so happy that it was nicknamed "laughing gas."

A mouthpiece is placed over the patient's mouth and nose so he or she can inhale the ether fumes.

Small pieces of sponge soaked in ether give off fumes.



A toe is numbed using a local anesthetic before minor surgery.

LOCAL ANESTHETICS

The right dose of ether or chloroform knocked a patient out cold, but too large a dose could result in death. In 1903, the French chemist Ernest Fourneau developed Amylocaine, the first artificial local anesthetic. It numbed the body part to be operated on but left the patient conscious. Many other local anesthetics have since been created.



GENERAL ANESTHETICS

Modern-day general anesthetics are usually a combination of different drugs that make a patient lose consciousness during an operation. The dosages are controlled by an anesthetic machine—also known as Boyle's machine, after the British doctor Henry Boyle who invented it in 1917. During surgery, an anesthetist (the person on the far right, above) administers and monitors the anesthetics.